us to understand the varied cultural geographies, or the "many Indias," which the Shansabanis encountered, further bearing out their adaptive and region-specific approach to building and consolidating a confederate empire.

Gandhara and Swat

Even the westernmost reaches of the Indic cultural world – now within modern Pakistan and eastern Afghanistan – were far from an unvarying or uniform cultural geography. Rather, I propose that the region comprised at least two discernible architectural–cultural areas: the first, in the north interconnecting upper Panjab through historical Gandhara and Swat; the second, in the south encompassing Sindh, the Makran coast, and eastern Baluchistan. The differing – though *not* divergent, but rather complementary – historical trajectories of these respective areas from the early historic period onward, and their distinct cultural productions, necessitate their separate treatment. Albeit brief, this examination allows us to trace the varied landscapes the Ghazna Shansabanis came upon during their first forays eastward.

Mu'izz al-Din's campaign to Peshawar (AH 575/1179–1180 CE) – and most likely beyond into the surrounding valleys – brought him and the Ghazna Shansabanis face to face with a region that was home to various flourishing communities, whose identities crisscrossed confessional and occupational axes of belonging. Major Buddhist monasteries (Figure 6.1)



Figure 6.1 *Buddhist monastic complex, Takht-i Bahi, Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa Province, Pakistan. © Photograph Alka Patel 1997.*